

Coq au vin with carrots & rice

Serves 4 | Start 3:45 p.m. | Serve 6:00 p.m. | Wide 5-6 qt Dutch oven + rice cooker

INGREDIENTS

2 lb thawed boneless chicken thighs, left whole
4 oz bacon, cut into small strips
10 oz frozen pearl onions (small round onions)
10 oz mushrooms, quartered
3 medium carrots (about 250 g), in ½-inch pieces
3 garlic cloves, chopped; 1 tbsp tomato paste
½ tsp fine salt; ½ tsp black pepper

2 cups dry red wine, preferably Pinot Noir or Gamay
1-1½ cups unsalted chicken stock, ideally gelatin-rich
1 tsp dried thyme; 1 dried bay leaf
2 tbsp cold unsalted butter; neutral oil as needed
Optional thickener: 1 tbsp each soft butter and flour
Rice: 1½ US cups dry white rice (about 280 g),
water per cooker directions; butter and salt to taste

METHOD & DINNER TIMELINE

3:45 | Prep. Thaw pearl onions per package, drain and dry thoroughly. Cut vegetables. Pat chicken very dry; season with measured salt and pepper. Refrigerate until searing. Dry surfaces brown better; wet food cools the pan and steams.

4:00 | Render bacon. Cook over medium heat for 8-10 minutes until browned and fat renders. Lift out. Leave 2 tbsp fat; supplement with oil if needed.

4:10 | Brown chicken. Unfold thighs and sear in two uncrowded batches over medium-high heat: 3-4 minutes on the first side, then 2 minutes on the other. Brown the surface; the centers will finish in the braise. Set aside. Keep the pan residue brown, never black; lower heat if needed. Pour off excess fat, leaving 2 tbsp.

4:25 | Brown vegetables. Cook mushrooms 10-12 minutes, letting released water evaporate before browning. Add onions and carrots; cook 6-8 minutes, stirring, until lightly colored. Add garlic, tomato paste and thyme; stir 1 minute.

4:45 | Reduce wine. Pour in wine and scrape up brown residue. Simmer uncovered about 10-15 minutes, until the wine volume is roughly halved. This concentrates flavor; it does not remove all alcohol. Add 1 cup stock, bay and bacon. Cover and gently simmer the vegetables for 10 minutes to give the carrots a head start.

5:10-5:40 | Gentle braise. Nestle chicken and its juices into the sauce; add stock only if needed to reach halfway to two-thirds up the meat. Cover and maintain slow, occasional bubbles. Check after 20 minutes; allow about 25-35 minutes, until the thickest thighs reach at least 165°F and are tender. Lift out cooked pieces promptly. Check carrots with a knife; if still firm, let them simmer while chicken rests.

By 4:45 | Rice cooker. Rinse rice and drain. Use the cooker's water instructions for that rice and quantity; US cups are not cooker cups. Add optional salt/butter. Run the white-rice cycle, then Keep Warm. Start earlier if its cycle exceeds 65 minutes. Rest covered 10 minutes after cooking, then fluff at serving.

5:40-5:55 | Adjust sauce. Lift out chicken and vegetables; discard bay. Skim pooled fat. Simmer uncovered 5-15 minutes until sauce lightly coats a spoon. If flavor is already concentrated but sauce stays thin, mash the optional soft butter and flour together; whisk in a little at a time and simmer 5 minutes. If too salty or sharp, loosen with unsalted stock instead of reducing further.

5:55-6:00 | Finish and serve. Return chicken and vegetables; keep hot on very low heat. Just before serving, turn off heat, let bubbling stop, and swirl in the 2 tbsp cold butter in pieces for gloss. Taste before adding salt. Do not boil after finishing. Fluff rice and spoon chicken, vegetables and sauce beside or over it.

For this cut: Boneless thighs need a shorter braise than bone-in pieces. Keep them whole and use doneness cues, not the clock alone. With less skin/connective tissue in the pot, gelatin-rich stock or the optional flour thickener helps give the sauce body.

Adapted from Mise's coq au vin, with technique comparisons: Raymond Blanc; Le Cordon Bleu; Daniel Gritzer / Serious Eats; Jenn Segal. Safety: USDA FSIS.